

EASIA 237 Qingming Module Unit 2.mp4

Welcome back, everybody. This is the second lecture in the module about the Qingming Hand Scroll. Today we'll be addressing some lingering questions about the painting, including some different arguments about issues as fundamental as the city represented in the painting, when it was made, the period, the significance of some of these issues. So what I'll be covering today: I'll begin by first addressing some basic things to keep in mind about the research article assigned for reading today. This will be on slides two and three. After that, one of the issues I'll discuss related to these research articles is The kind of intended audience of this kind of publication and some of the things that the writer might presume their readers already know.

And in this case, one of those things is some basic details about the historical period during which this painting was created and, of course, the period that's represented in the painting. So, because some of these issues aren't really discussed in a lot of detail in the article, I'll give you some brief, sort of very fast overview of a complex period of Chinese history: the Northern and Southern Song dynasties, and then quickly have some points about what this actually has to do with the scroll. Of course this is the period the painting was made in. Of course, it's important, but the things I'll focus on in this historical overview are directly relevant to some of these questions that scholars are asking about what exactly we see being represented in this painting.

So, after that, in addition to summarizing and talking through the perspective in the article that we've all read in preparation for today's lecture, I'll also go into a bit more detail about two additional perspectives on the same question. So, scholars who, in this case, disagree with one another. This will be on slides seven through eleven. I'm actually going to start with an expanded version of an idea that's already expressed in the reading that we did for the last unit of this module. I'll be drawing from a source that Hanson also wrote, that she cites a few times throughout that introduction to the scroll that we all read together. So her main argument is already expressed in this reading that we did for the last unit.

But in this case, I'll be referring to kind of an expanded and more detailed version of that, talk a bit more about some of the evidence that she uses to argue that what we actually see represented in the scroll is not, in fact, the city of Kaifeng. but a kind of imaginary, idealized city that represents a sort of nostalgic perspective on an earlier period of history. After this, we will expand our discussion to include the reading assigned for this lecture: Cao Xinyuan's article about the very same painting, in which she argues that the city that we see represented in the painting is, in fact, Kaifeng, and for fairly particular reasons that, of course, we'll talk about quite a bit as we move forward.

This is not just the city of Kaifeng, but in fact, it must be the city of Kaifeng before the year 1079, so sometime in the mid 11th century, let's say. Then after that, I'll provide a third perspective who makes the argument that, similar to others, this is the city of Kaifeng; but then, rather than create a kind of idealized, imaginary, peaceful and idyllic city, this is in fact a kind of criticism of some of the things going on in this Northern Song period. So, the argument about the location is similar to

that made by other scholars and the popular understanding of what the scroll represents. But the kind of iconoclastic element of this third argument is that we sort of reimagine this painting not as a kind of celebration of the city of Kaifeng in the Northern Song, but as a sort of subtle critique of some aspects.

of that historical period. So after this, I'll present you with these three different arguments. And I think for our purposes we might want to think about which of these arguments is more persuasive. But really, the main goal of this is to think about this as an ongoing question; one that is very difficult for specialists to answer. And then think really about the significance of that controversy or disagreement, rather than really try to settle on which one of those represents the correct perspective. So I'll have some more to say about that towards the end. And then that will lead us in, as usual, to a brief introduction of the Associated assignments and quiz for this part of the module.

So, before we dive in, I'd like to say a little bit about this article that we read for this lecture and the kind of style of publication, I guess, style of writing it is that we're seeing in general. So, this is what we'll refer to in this class and probably elsewhere as a research article. In comparison to some things we've already read, I think that the easiest text to compare it to would be what I've referred to as a chapter in an edited book rather than an introduction to that book or some other kind of publication. The difference is what we call the container publication. right. Whereas these chapters in edited books are published in relatively narrowly focused, one-time publications, you know, a book with a single editor or maybe a pair of editors who sort of gathered together a bunch of independent but very closely related studies of similar topics.

In this case, a research article is published in a different container source. That's what we call an academic journal, which is peer-reviewed. That means anonymous readers read through all of these articles, make their critiques, and give their advice for how the author should revise it before it is published. These publications are not just one. time things. It's not a book that would be hardbound, perhaps sitting on the shelf of a library, but it's what we call a periodical publication, meaning the journal publishes multiple issues. Some really specialized journals publish only one issue per year. Others publish more frequently, sometimes two or even four issues every year. So this is an ongoing sort of project to put together recent research on related fields that's largely intended to be read by other specialists in those fields.

So, of particular importance for the kind of vetted for basic degree of, you know, the style of writing, the sort of facts they cite, the argument cites evidence that actually exists. This kind of thing peer-reviewed doesn't necessarily mean that what is published in every article is going to be something that all other scholars in the field agree on, right? Scholars love to disagree with one another. Just because an article is published doesn't mean that it sort of invalidates every piece of research that's ever been written on the same topic. These are parts of sort of ongoing discussions and debates, and that's, you know, part of the fun, but it can also be challenging to keep up with many different perspectives and opinions about all of these different.

topics So setting that aside for now, the sort of main type of writing you'll see in one of these

academic journals are research articles. Again, these sort of 20-30 page papers that tend to put forth relatively focused arguments that draw on a variety of, you know, primary sources other perspectives to use to, you know, make those arguments to use as support for the points that they're making. There are some other components that we'll see in academic journals. I think for our purposes we don't really need to worry about those for now. One really important thing, and something that is often overlooked when we're looking through These kinds of reading the title of the journal right, not necessarily — well, the title of the article is, of course, extremely important.

It tells you the specific topic that the author is writing about, but the name of the journal, that is, the name of the periodical publication that contains these articles, is also very important. It might be relatively broad, but you can actually learn a lot by paying attention to the title of that journal. So, an edited book, again, is going to have a fairly narrow title that's going to tell you precisely what all of the chapters in that book have to do with one another. The title of a journal is going to be somewhat broader, but it's also extremely important. So what I encourage you to do every time you're assigned to read something like a research article is to look not just at the title of the, but at the title of the publication that contains it, and then think about what this suggests.

Right? What does the title of this journal tell you about who this article is for? Because scholars, when they're, you know, writing, when they're deciding where they want to publish their research, they'll think a lot about the different journals that are available to them, and then they're also kind of expected to present their argument in a way that's So in this case, the article that we're reading for this unit is from a publication called the Journal of Song Yuan Studies. Now, if you don't know what those two proper nouns mean, these are two periods of pre-Chinese history. So, in this case, the title of the journal tells us that this is intended for readers who all share an interest in this particular period of Chinese history; that is, the 10th through the 14th centuries, roughly.

What it also tells us is that, even though we know the topic of this particular article has a very strong connection to art history, the history of painting, and the history of various art styles. We can sort of infer that the people who the author of the article expects to be reading her work are not necessarily other art historians. These are not necessarily scholars whose main focus is specifically on painting, representational art, or other aspects of art history, either within the Song Yuan period or other parts of Chinese history, or other parts of the world. Instead, she's writing for an audience of people who are probably interested in a lot of different aspects of the culture and history of this period of China.

So it's worth thinking then about how does this article sort of connects to those interests, right? How. did they sort of present their argument in a way that's going to make sense to people who may not know a whole lot about the narrow field of art history, but they might know quite a bit about other aspects of this particular period of Chinese history? And then you might think about, you know, well, if this author was writing for an audience of other art historians, right, perhaps, let's say, they wanted to publish this in a journal that wasn't even focused on Chinese or East Asian art, but was focused on the discipline of art history in general, right? They might present their readers with different information in the introduction to help them understand the argument that they're making.

The argument itself might be exactly the same, but it's going to be sort of surrounded by other contextual information that will help it make sense to other people who might also, you know, be reading this journal for other reasons. So, by the same sort of manner, we could also say, well, what does this author presume or expect their audience is already going to? And this is why I'm adding this component to this lecture that's going to give us some of this background on song history, especially that might be sort of taken for granted by the author of this. So, this is why it's sort of If you feel like you're missing something, you might want to look back at, oh, this is a journal that's intended for this type of audience.

And so it kind of makes sense that they're not going to go into a lot of detail about these kinds of background things. And perhaps you might want to rely on other sources to get that context. In this class, I'll try to provide it in these lectures and other resources. So before we dive into any of these arguments, before we dive into that historical background, just a few more quick thoughts about reading research articles. One thing that can be a bit confusing, perhaps frustrating, if you're used to reading research in the sciences where from my experience publications tend to follow a fairly standardized format where you have very clearly labeled sections with experiment design, abstract, conclusions, things like this.

We tend to see in humanities research, cultural studies, history, this kind of thing, there's a lot of variety in how scholars might choose to organize and structure their articles. And it's not necessarily going to follow a very predictable format with very clearly labeled sections telling you the purpose of every part of that study. This is what makes reading these sometimes very interesting. but it can be hard to get the most out of them if you don't really know what to expect when you dive in. One thing that might not always be that indicated is that despite the sort of creative freedom that a lot of humanities scholars take when organizing and writing these, most will be encouraged strongly to include something like a thesis statement somewhere in the introduction.

It's not going to be on the first page necessarily, certainly not always at the end of the very first paragraph. But somewhere in the first few pages, you're likely to see some sentence that very bluntly states what the purpose of the article is. These are often expressed really directly. They'll say something like, 'In this article, I will argue; I will prove; I will demonstrate' something like this, or maybe even, 'My argument is blah blah blah something like that. Again, this is going to be worded differently in every article, but they'll use some kind of sentence structure that has this kind of format to it. And these are the most important sentences in the article— really important to find this and to understand it before you read the rest of the publication.

And this is also a reason, by the way, why just sort of skimming through the first page and then moving on is not necessarily a good strategy for reading this kind of publication because unless you're paying attention to where the scholar is saying, you know, this is what I'm actually might be kind of easy to get confused and assume that some of the stuff that comes up in the first page is going to be some other way of expressing what this author actually is arguing or what they believe. So one reason for this is because another thing that you're likely to see in the first few pages of

these articles are summaries of the work that's already been done by other people. In many cases, this is sort of establishing, you know, here are the points that have already.

been made about this topic. So what I'm going to be doing is something new, right? This sort of contributes to an ongoing conversation about the topic of their article, which is inevitably something that someone else has already written about. So sometimes it's just sort of, here's what's already happened. This is the next step. In other cases, and this is the case of what we're reading today, the studies that are summarized in the beginning are actually things that the author doesn't agree with, right? They're saying, here's what other people have; I think they're wrong. Here is the actual answer to this question. So it's really important not to get these two things mixed up, right? To kind of confuse arguments made by other people that are summarized in the article that you're reading with the argument that the scholar is actually making in this publication.

So the reason this is so important is that as you read on, you'll find that the article might take some tangents, right? They might move into directions that don't seem that related to other aspects of the article. If you're able to keep in mind, you know, the reason all of this is happening has been expressed in some way in the first few pages. Sometimes you may have to do the work of thinking, well, okay. This seems kind of random. It seems to be sort of talking about other issues. What does this have to do with that argument? How can I connect it back to help me understand this main point that they're making? So ideally, you'll be able to do this.

Sometimes the author will do this for you, but other times it might be necessary to think a little bit more about how all these components relate to one another. So what I'd like you to do before we continue, you might want to pause here, return to the assigned reading for this unit, reread that introduction, and find the sentence where the author tells us the point of the article, right? Tells us her argument. And if you have this in mind, I think everything else will make a lot more sense. And by the way, if you haven't already done so, I also recommend you know pausing here and actually reading through that article if you haven't yet taken the opportunity to do that. So now that you've refreshed your memory about the topic of the main perspective, we'll be looking at today.

First, I'll give you some background details about the period during which this painting was made and then move on to talking about our three perspectives on the significance of the painting and what it So the Song Dynasty we understand as this period. of Chinese history can actually be divided into two halves, more or less, halves of unequal length. The first of these is called the Northern Song, lasted from 960 to 1127. It's so called Northern because its capital, the city that was at the time known as Bianliang, has a variety of other names, sometimes the Eastern Capital, confusing. The city that's now known as, and I'll use Kaifeng to refer to this just because it's a single, relatively familiar city name.

So it's called the Northern Song because this capital city was located, relative to other parts of this period, located in the North, right? The capital is in the North, it's also kind of in the but we call it the Northern Song in relation to what comes after. Lots of stuff going on in this period of Chinese history, most significantly, and certainly most significantly for the topic of today's lecture, is that

this is a state that sort of coexists with a number of rival states to the North, West, and East. Right? This is an emergence of a kind of complex, sort of like multipolar situation in Chinese history in which we have many different rivals contending with one another, having sort of complex diplomatic relations, eventually sort of dissolving into wars between these various other states.

Our purposes. The most important of these is the state ruled by Jurchen peoples in the Northeast that comes to be known as the Jin State or Jin Dynasty, the last of these three here. So, in the Song, we have this complex diplomatic situation, and we have a lot of debates in government about what the best way to contend with these rival states is, how to manage this increasingly tense diplomatic situation, and then, of course, after this, how to sort of fight the wars against these states that begin in various times. To make a long story short, whichever sort of paths to negotiate with these states the Song take, they're not successful. In 1127, this northern Song period comes to an end when this Jin state in the northeast kind of expands to the south and eventually conquers all of the territory in this northern area formerly controlled by the Song.

So, this begins the second half of the Song period that we refer to as the southern Song because this government that was once located in the city now known as is basically relocated to the south. So, this happens a number of times in Chinese history. Consequences are always a little bit different, but basically, what we have in this situation many of those members of the government flee to the south. Some of them remain in the city of Kaifeng and other territories that have been conquered. So we have this kind of divided situation where the northern part of China is ruled by this state called Jin. The southern part, roughly south of the Yangtze River, more or less is ruled by this government that was once centered in Kaifeng, that has now moved first to the city now known as Nanjing, and then, more famously for a longer period of time, to the city that was at the time known as Lin'an, that's now known as Hangzhou.

So, not that far from the city of Nanjing in this kind of Yangtze River Valley area, just south of the Yangtze River. Hence the name Southern Song. So we have the northern Song, with its capital in Kaifeng. Following the Jin invasion, they flee to the south, re-establish that capital eventually in what's now the city of Hangzhou. This is not entirely like a dismal period. You might sort of think following invasion, following conquest, things can be somewhat grim. But during this period, as you can see, the Song government remains in power for quite some time after this. We have this kind of increasing cultural, economic, and agricultural development in this southern Yangtze River region. At the same time, this earlier period, during which the capital was in Kaifeng, especially the middle years was remembered as a time of peace, in some cases contrasted against what comes later.

But by others, depending on how they viewed this, they might critique this so-called time of peace as a time of naivete, a time of not paying attention to the things that mattered, to put it lightly. Hence, the sort of subsequent conquest of that city and surrounding territory by one of these rival states. And so this controversy, hopefully, you can start to think about how this might relate to what we see represented in this painting. Just to sort of look ahead, the end of this period and hence the sort of Song Yuan studies as a kind of discrete. Period of Chinese history ends with the conquest, first of the Jin in the year 1234, and then a little while after this, of the southern Song in

1279, beginning the sort of next phase of the history of the period.

So just to kind of visualize this a little bit, we can see here a map representing roughly the northern Song with rival states of Liao and Xixia, or western Xia, here; a city of Kaifeng on the. So what happens is the state of Jin kind of emerges from roughly this area, first conquers the state of Liao, occupying roughly the same territory, and then eventually expands their territory further south, displacing the Song government. forcing the central government to move from the city of Kaifeng first to Nanjing and then eventually to the city of Hangzhou. And so we can see this kind of border here between the Jin and the southern Song, representing this new kind of situation in this later period. So what does this have to do with this painting?

It's tempting, in any case, in any sort of art historical context, to think about, you know, how does a painting reflect the sort of broader context of the period in which it was made or the period that it shows? But if we want to do this, we need to be precise, right, about when it was made and what exactly we see in the And these are details that are not they're not established definitively in any kind of evidence. Right? There's no part of the colophons to the or anything else in it that say this painting 100% represents this city in this year, and my intention for painting it was this. Right? We don't have that kind of supporting information from the. Instead, as we pointed out in the last unit, we know the name of this painter.

We know a little bit about, you know, the kind of skills that he had as an. We don't even really know exactly when he lived, and we certainly don't know exactly why he made this painting. Mostly, what we have are later people's impressions. of why they think it. So if we want to make an argument about, you know, what's the significance of this painting, we need to have something more to go on. Hence, all of this, you know, subsequent debate about the painting and its subject. Now, one thing I pointed out right in this Southern Song context, that is, after Kaifeng is no longer the capital, after this government has been sort of relocated to these other cities, there's a lot of what we call literati culture, the sort of cultural practices, art forms, poetry, writing, and so on.

A lot of this is about sort of remembering this earlier period, right? Whether we're remembering it positively. or negatively or a kind of complex mix in people's minds. In between, there's a lot of sort of energy in this period of history devoted to recalling elements of daily life in this earlier period. So, one of the most famous examples of this, one that's cited in a lot of the studies that we're reading, is what we can call, I think, a memoir sort of diary-style text by an author named Meng Yuanlao. Title in Chinese is Dongjing Menghua Lu. English translation of this is Glorious Dreams of the Eastern Capital. This is the translation that's used in Cao's article and a number of other sources. And we can see it was first published in 1147, right.

So it was published after some decades after the city of Kaifeng had been conquered and was under new leadership. So what this represents, and again this author is like a lot of figures in this period, we don't necessarily know exactly when he lived, but we know that his life spanned the sort of late Northern and early Southern Song period, right? So he's one of these people that experienced the city of Kaifeng when it was the, and then wrote about those experiences and memories in this very famous, it's sort of like a travel log, but about a city that this person actually

lived in. So we can think of this as representing this author's. actual experiences of living in the city, but it's one that he's doing in retrospect, right?

He's sort of thinking back on an earlier time, which is inevitably going to kind of condition the way that you recall that period. This in itself is important, right? The passage of time changes how we think about earlier time. So if we're writing something down as we're experiencing it, we're inevitably gonna write about it in a different way than we would if we're thinking back 20, 30 years later, no matter what happens, right? Now, consider if you've experienced the sort of massive period of chaos and turmoil and then ended up living in a very different era and perhaps even in the case of many people who experienced this relocating to a different place, leaving behind this city that was once quite familiar to you. So, experience versus memory and nostalgia, right?

The other layer to this then is that this document, right this book, *Glorious Dreams of the Eastern Capital*, then becomes a source that other people who maybe didn't even experience this particular period of history, they might read a book like this and then think about like, oh what would it have been like if I was living in this time period, right? And these experiences can also be very meaningful. to the people that read about them. So we might have, you know, our own ideas about earlier periods of history that we didn't actually experience, but these things can still prove to be like very emotional. We can form very strong, you know, senses of identity, senses of culture, senses of, you know, what has been lost in this early period, even if it's something that we didn't actually experience.

But this is going to be, again, something a little bit different than either something that was composed as these experiences were happening, something that was composed by someone who lived through them, but is then sort of looking back. on them. And then finally, the people who are the audience for that type of writing, right, who sort of, you know, experience vicariously these memories and nostalgic ideas about earlier periods. And so, all of this is also at stake when we think about the kinds of things that are represented in this painting, with the added complexity that, you know, because a painting is representative, I think especially in contemporary times, we tend to think of this as having an almost photographic quality, right? Everyone will praise, you know, the realism of a painting like the *Qingming Scroll*.

And we can say that it is realistic, right? It doesn't have any sort of overtly fantastical or sort of something that we can tell on the surface is just very heavily embellished. It seems to capture a kind of social reality. And yet we do need to keep in mind that this is not a photograph, right? This is not a literal snapshot of an actual moment of. It's something that is inevitably going to feature some degree of artistic license, let's call it, right? Creative composition, something like this, right? So regardless of what any of these scholars are arguing, I think all would agree there's something kind of idealized or imagined about this painting. It's just the sort of degree to which we're thinking about that artistic license, right? So all of this idea of experience, memory, nostalgia, cultural memory certainly also applies to painting, with the added complexity of the sort of illusion of realism, I suppose we could call it.

So moving on, let's recap Hansen's argument that we read a little bit about in the last unit. This is

based on an expanded version of this argument that appears in a longer article that's not required reading, but if you'd like to check it out, it is in the additional reading section that you can find by downloading the PowerPoint presentation from the course website. So in this source, what Hansen argues is that you know, even more so than just all painting being, in some way, kind of imagined and idealized, what we see here is not even an attempt to represent the city of Kaifeng, but instead represents a kind of imagined, ideal city. Some elements of it might be inspired by something kind of like Kaifeng, but there's not really any deliberate effort to signal to readers that this is certainly this particular city of northern Song.

And so the idea is that this was most likely painted after the fall of the northern Song and kind of exists in this sort of realm of nostalgia, right? The evidence that Hansen cites to argue this is that there's a lot of what we might call missed opportunities to really clearly signal to the viewer of the painting that what we are looking at is the city of Kaifeng, right? This is a city that's fairly well documented in sources like the Mengyuan Lao text I was just talking about. We know a lot about what different parts of the city were named, especially very large structures like the city gate. There's no sort of calligraphic inscriptions telling us like, oh, this is the eastern gate of the city that would be known from geographic texts and other sorts of writings from the period.

The other interesting thing that she points out is that even though this is called Qingming, we don't see a lot of overt evidence of any of the celebrations that would have been associated with this particular holiday in this Song period. And on top of this, we also see some kind of inconsistent seasonal imagery, again reflecting the idea that rather than saying, you know, this is Kaifeng in the springtime, what we see in the painting is more like an ideal city where we sort of travel through several different seasons as we go. She goes into detail about how some people are fanning themselves, implying extreme heat. Other people are maybe wearing more clothing. In some scenes of the painting suggesting later or earlier cooler seasons.

There's this kind of inconsistent seasonal imagery throughout the And that suggests again this kind of idealized imaginary version rather than like a specific place or moment in time. So instead, what she argues is that Qingming doesn't apply to the period of the year in which the painting is set, quote unquote, but rather the kind of alternate interpretation of these terms to mean something like, you know, brilliance and peace, something like this. And here is another idealized element that we see in the painting. Rather than, you know, a snapshot of different parts of the city where we might see some less-than-ideal conditions of like an urban environment. In this painting, we don't really see any evidence of extreme poverty. We see watchtowers, but they don't have guardsmen on them.

We don't see any kind of militarization either within or outside of the city. We see sort of relatively few fortifications, again sort of contributing to this idea that this is not the city of Kaifeng in the northern Song. Because if it were, we would see more sort of ramparts and other sort of fortifications that are being built in, you know, sort of with the knowledge that there are these rival states who all have ambitions to conquer this capital city. And so instead, what we see in the painting is a kind of too good to be true version of what like a perfect urban environment might look like. Another part of Hanson's argument that she doesn't address in the reading we read for

the last part of this module,

she also goes into detail, sort of comparing not what we see in the painting, but the way that it's painted, talking about style and technique, and using this to sort of contribute to our argument that what we see here is characteristic of art made in the mid and late 12th century. And this sort of supports her idea that this is not painted during the Northern Song but is painted sort of after this period, drawing from later art techniques to create an image of the past. So why does this matter? Why does it matter that what we see is an idealized city rather than one city in, and that it's likely to have been painted sometime after the period that it represents?

So who might connect this to some of these other ideas about this sort of like Southern Song, or rather post Northern Song context in which a lot of artistic and creative energy in the culture is devoted to creating these kinds of nostalgic tributes to daily life in the Northern Song and doing it in a way that's not necessarily connected to any one city or period of the year specifically. So we might think of this as a kind of visual counterpart to a memoir like the one written by Meng Yuanlao, but where that text goes into a lot of very elaborate detail about places and buildings and shops and specific names of people and things like this, what we have in the sort of painted version of is one that focuses more on the atmosphere, one that focuses more on the idea of this peaceful urban city in this earlier period of history.

And so this is not necessarily neutral, you know what I mean? By creating an image like this. we might also read it as a kind of implicit critique of the period during which the painting was made, saying you know, look how great things used to be. Of course, it's not like this now, right? But they're using a kind of imagined version of the past in order to make that argument. So with that sort of earlier perspective out of the way, this is something that the author of this article kind of briefly references in the introduction, but then hopefully fairly quickly— and hopefully you saw this when you were reviewing it— Hansen's argument is one that this author cites as a kind of point of disagreement, right?

This is what an earlier scholar has written about this topic. Here is my perspective, which, in fact, as we'll see, is quite different. So, the argument that this author makes, that the city represented in the painting is, in fact, Kaifeng and that it actually represents a very particular time of the year, that is around the Qingming Festival, but it's not actually that concerned with any of these festival or holiday traditions. So, the title of the painting does come from the time of the year, but the interest of the painter is not in sort of capturing this like holiday atmosphere, and that's why we don't see any of the kind of details about those celebrations. But instead, the theme that the artist is hoping to call to mind is a very particular sort of seasonal activity at this point in that sort of results from the river thawing out and then being reopened for trading.

So I'll get into some of the finer points of this, but I would say if we wanted to summarize the significance of this in general, we might say that one of the big ideas in this article is that kind of expanding on this idea of experience and then later cultural memory is thinking about maybe what's left behind, what sort of fades out of view as time goes by. So what are some of these fundamental aspects of daily life in one period? that might be sort of diminished and eventually

forgotten later representations of that era. So let's think about how the author makes her argument. So what points does she raise to counter this argument, to what we see as a kind of idealized sort of generic city, to say that in fact this is the city of Kaifeng?

She first points out, scrutinizes in a little more detail the fact that we see so many different wine shops in the city, including both a primary wine shop where we know that the raw materials for brewing this liquor would be turned into wine, and then the secondary wine shops which were legally not allowed to create their own wine but bought it from the primary wine shops or used distributors to move it throughout the city. We see a lot of these, including one very large primary wine shop, several other secondary wine shops, to suggest a very large city with a kind of thriving market for this product. So, not just any city but a kind of metropolis, we might call it.

More specifically, she points to one easily overlooked detail and kind of has a lot of interesting things to say about how it actually may not have been possible for scholars who didn't have the opportunity to look at the scroll up close or kind of looking at it from poorly reproduced photographs. and this kind of thing. While we might say, like, yes in general, there's a kind of absence of very specific details that we can use to connect it very overtly to the city. If you look closely, you can see in one of these secondary wine shops there are these two characters here: Meilu, which is the name of a specific kind of wine that's known to have been produced in.

So there is like a little bit of sort of city-specific labeling on some of the stuff in the just not very prominently featured. These are kind of supporting points. But I think what really is more convincing that this must be the city of Kaifeng is the sort of broader theme of. the painting and what Cao argues it actually represents. And so here she explains that in addition to being the name of a holiday, it's also the name of a solar term. Let's call it like a segment of the calendar, right, that correlates to early spring, roughly. It's one of these 24 divisions of the solar calendar used for agricultural purposes, based on the seasons, the movement of the sun, and this kind of thing.

So the Qingming period is early spring, during which the ice on the rivers would be thawing out, which would allow freer transport of goods using these like shipping routes along the waterways connected to the city of. So these Rivers and canals would be kind of shut down for trade during the As the ice thaws, they're reopened, sort of bringing back to life a lot of the sort of commercial activities in the capital city. And so, if we have this kind of seasonal activity in mind, then we can see, oh, this is actually a theme of the painting. So we see grain ships returning. We see these wine shops are kind of busy with activity again, thanks to increased access to all of these different goods that would not have been able to bring into the city for many months.

We see maybe some even like exaggerated representations of warmer weather. So these kind of people fanning. themselves right. It might not actually be quite so hot in early spring, but this sort of brings to mind this idea of like, oh, the winter has been so long. Now it's warming up again. Things are sort of hotter than they used to be, right? So it's a kind of like heightened spring atmosphere, celebrating the return of trade to the The reason why she's able to argue that this must be before the year 1079 is because this year is when these canals were rerouted; the sort of trade system was redesigned. And so it was no longer necessary to shut them down in the winter.

They kind of allowed for a year-long transportation of And so this really momentous.

event that happens in the early spring after these canals are rerouted. I think in the grand scheme of things, this is a good thing, right? You're able to have trade going in and out of the city all year long. So gradually, this what would have perhaps at the time been a very significant association for people living in Kaifeng, right? This Qingming part of the year is not just the time when we celebrate this holiday, but it's the time where the city sort of returns to life. The canals are reopened. We can purchase new things. Things are warming up again. Gradually, since the sort of reopening of the canals is no longer such a pivotal event, people sort of lose track of that association. And so it's not something that we tend to see emphasized in later texts.

So why is this important? How can we connect this to some bigger ideas? We might think about this in relation to changing memories, changing representations of the city of. So for those people living earlier in the 11th century, this might have been a very familiar moment in the year. This would be part of Kaifeng culture; it would be part of daily life, the sort of yearly cycle for people living in the city. But in fact, it's not mentioned by this writer, Meng Yuanlao. And this makes sense because we know that he was active in the late 11th, so probably, maybe he was a child when this happened; maybe he was born slightly after the canals were rerouted.

This isn't part of his experience living in the city of And so what he writes about the city that's largely based on his own memories of this late sort of post-1079 atmosphere in the city. This text really goes on to define this cultural memory of the city for later audiences. And so, because it was written after this earlier period, that early spring moment is not something that sticks really firmly in the minds of these later readers. So what does this have to do with the scroll itself? Well, in fact, as Tsao briefly points out we know there's hundreds of later versions of the I talked earlier in the last unit about how many of them are from much later periods and sort of represent other cities and so on.

There are also quite a few that, like many, believe to be true about the scroll sort of purport to represent Kaifeng in the Northern Song period. And the way they do this, because they're painted long after this period ended, we can sort of see where the authors are reading through Meng Yuanlao's memoirs and saying, like, oh, he writes about this wine shop, he writes about this district, and all of these things, I'm going to put those things in my painting because this represents what everybody in this later period sort of thinks is important about this older period of Kaifeng history. And so this then kind of changes the way we think about Zhang Zeduan's original painting, right? Zhang Zeduan is not working from Meng Yuanlao's text.

He's not working with the understanding of what later audiences come to expect from things that represent Northern Song Kaifeng. And so then we start to, oh, he doesn't have all of these local landmarks in the same way that these later imitations of his own painting have kind of added to it. And then it makes us suspicious, right? We might say, well, why doesn't he have any of these landmarks in it? Well, one possible answer to this is that if we presume that this painter is working in this pre-1079 context, he's living in a world in which this reopening of the canals is such a significant local event, maybe it's not necessary to have any other labels, have any other really

overt signifiers of what city we're in.

Perhaps the assumption is that an audience living in this actual pre-1079 period would, seeing all of these ships coming in, seeing the sort of warm atmosphere, seeing all of the kind of celebration of the kind of tavern culture that's made possible by these grain shipments maybe that earlier audience would have said oh of course what we're seeing here is the city of Kaifeng during early spring. They don't need any of these other labels and signifiers that later people come to expect. So then moving forward into these even later versions of the painting they're working you know several degrees of separation away from this no longer even really interested in representing the city of, certainly not interested in representing this kind of specific seasonal moment of the reopening of.

And yet they do bear a very close relationship to this original painting. And that is you know what sort of lasts in people's minds about the painting, this sort of general theme of a prosperous and peaceful city. So we have what was once perhaps created to kind of document or commemorate a very particular seasonal event, is remembered and understood by later audiences as a kind of general picture of a prosperous and peaceful city. And then this becomes the model for later sort of imitations or versions of the painting long after the song has ended, in which case they kind of apply this model to other cities in these later periods. So I do think this is fairly convincing, but just for the sake of rounding things.

out let's consider one more perspective on this original painting. So this comes from another art historical research, who's based at the National Palace Museum, you know, this location that holds the painting itself. So to make a complex argument short, what Yu Hui is arguing is that the city depicted is Kaifeng. But in fact, rather than think of this as a kind of idealized, perfect version of the city, we should scrutinize the details that it includes and read this instead as a critique of the sort of pointing out some flaws and oversights in the design of the city and the way it was managed in the kind of urban culture of Kaifeng. In the northern Seoul. So here we see, you know, a different opinion, a different perspective on a lot of the details that both of these other scholars have also noted.

Of course, they can't change what's in the painting, right? They're all basing their arguments on the same primary source but thinking about them slightly differently. So here are some details that are noted, both in, you know, Hansen's, also sort of briefly noted in some parts of the article that we read in detail. Yuhui points to this lack of fortifications and what Hansen characterizes as a kind of, like, ideally harmonious city in which none of these things are necessary. You know thinking about what comes after, perhaps it would have been better to build a city with more fortifications, right? So if we're thinking about this as like a retrospective critique of the lack of preparedness of the city for its, like, you know, soon-to-come invasion by the sort of Jin armies from the northeast.

If we see the sort of lacks of fortifications, lacks of guards, this is not necessarily a great situation for a city to be in, right? So we can kind of reinterpret this detail, knowing in retrospect, you know, this may have felt like a time of peace, but we could sort of also criticize it as a time of, you know, unpreparedness. for this coming change. Similarly, what we see on the surface is a very sort of

boisterous celebratory atmosphere. But, of course, there are different ways of interpreting this, right? If we see the sort of preponderance of wine shops throughout the city, which, you know, the previous article we discussed is used to argue that this is maybe kind of exaggerated in order to show the importance of, you know, grain arriving in the city after a long winter.

Here, we're kind of recharacterizing it, reinterpreting it as perhaps an indicator of a sort of dissolute, decadent society in which people are more interested in partying, you know. drinking wine, having a good time than thinking about the kind of social realities that they're living in. And one thing that Yuhui pays more attention to, if you think back to the last unit, you know that one of the last things represented in the painting is what Hansen and others point out is a kind of medicine stall that's marketing like cures for hangover, right? Which suggests, you know, perhaps not just, you know, a lively boisterous atmosphere, but drinking to the point of excess, right? Sort of symbolism for the kind of decadence of the period is that so many people are indulging that these kinds of medicine stalls marketing.

Hangover cures, as a kind of thriving business, we can kind of reinterpret this perhaps as a form of social critique, not just a kind of celebration of a prosperous city. Yuhui also has a different take on the presence of ships that we see throughout the painting. Of course, everyone agrees there are a lot of boats in this painting, but what this researcher argues is that we need to pay attention to the kind of boats that we see coming in and out of these sort of shipping areas in the city. So, Yuhui argues that these aren't just any boats, but these are kind of private, you know, privately owned vessels that are engaging in shipments. of grain for profit that this isn't part of the sort of government-owned fleet of ships that also would have potentially been used to create sort of more regular supply of resources to the city.

And then he sort of draws this connection to a critique that's often made of an emperor of the Northern Song who's, you know, blamed for a lot of different things. And one of the things that he's criticized for from these people taking this perspective that you know we need to think about the sort of failures of this Northern Song period, he's often criticized for making use of the imperial fleet, you know, the ships that are owned by the government sort of diverting them for his own sort of leisure purposes rather than using them to sort of fund the life, sort of supply goods to the city and so on. So we can say that, you know, this painting is perhaps referencing this oft-made critique of this emperor, showing how the imperial fleet is not being used properly and instead, you know, these private ships are coming in and out to fill that void.

So this is a very different perspective on the same events, right? Sort of shares with other arguments that what we see here is Northern Song Kaifeng, but we're kind of interpreting those details to suggest this is not holding. the city up as an example of an idealized perfect city but is, in fact, creating something that, on the surface, looks very prosperous but is certainly made with knowledge of what's coming, right? Knowledge of the fact that this supposed period of peace is very soon going to come to an end. So, suggesting again, you know, this is something that was painted after the fact. So what does this all mean? I've given you three very different perspectives on the same painting. It's very tempting to think, you know, we need to decide who is more persuasive, right?

Whose argument makes the most sense? It's not fair for me to ask you to do this because you've only really had the opportunity to read one of these people, so perhaps you might think you this particular article is more persuasive because you've taken the time to read through it, see all the points that are made. If we had unlimited time, perhaps we could read through all three of these and make some more kind of educated, informed evaluations of who we think has made this argument more clearly. To kind of cut this short, I'll say that all three are fairly persuasive, right? And all three are missing what we might call like smoking gun evidence, right? There's still no definitive point that's going to refute all of the other possible arguments about this painting and say, in fact, this scholar is right; these other two are definitely wrong.

Instead, I think we can say there are three possible interpretations of the significance of this painting, and honestly, probably even more. Right, I'm sure debate about this is going to continue. New arguments will be made, new details will be reinterpreted, and new sorts of points from historical context will be uncovered. Maybe one day, a sort of dominant perspective will emerge, but I would say, for the time being, there's likely to continue to be a lot of discussion about these kinds of details. One thing is true though. If these scholars are really interested in understanding, you know, how this painting relates to the context in which it was made, we need to be mindful of the fact that all of these hundreds of other versions are something else, right?

They're made after the fact; they're made for different purposes, made in slightly different contexts, and so we can't really use evidence that appears in these other versions and treat that as, you know, being of the same value as what we see in this oldest version of the painting itself. So from this perspective, it might seem that these later versions are kind of a distraction, right? They're sort of getting us further away from what remains a kind of ongoing, sort of compelling point of interest for these kinds of scholars analyzing with great scrutiny the contents of this original and much more mysterious version of this painting. So, it might seem that you know maybe these later versions don't matter; these are not authentic; they don't tell us about this very early context.

But, of course, these later versions are hugely important for other reasons, right? They're hugely important for understanding the legacy, for understanding perhaps how this painting becomes a part of what we could call cultural heritage. We can understand them as adaptations. We can understand them as lots of different things. It's just that they're not going to tell us that much about the context in which this original painting was made. So we could sort of set aside these unresolved questions about the original version of the painting. This is an ongoing point of contention, but on the other hand, we have something else is fairly clear: once we start paying attention to all of these later works, and that is that the idea that the Qingming scroll kind of comes to represent for later audiences is very well, and yet they all will invariably share certain.

features It's just that we kind of have to keep in mind that the features they share come from a lot of different sources. These aren't just, you know, higher resolution versions of the original painting. These later works draw, for example, as I pointed out earlier, many of them kind of pick and choose elements of this memoir of Northern Song Kaifeng by Meng Yanlao. They certainly also draw from their own artists' ideas and experiences, and when it comes to the Ning and Qing versions of the

painting that don't even attempt to represent Kaifeng or any sort of Northern Song city, these are of updating them with similarly specific and precise details about urban history and culture, their own times. So this is a kind of composite idea that draws from lots of different sources, right?

It's an adaptation that has sort of many sources of inspiration; many factors go into it, and it's a kind of ongoing form of, you know, a sort of sub-genre of art in itself, is just sort of recreating this painting using different ideas. And, but they do this to create something that's fairly consistent. And so in the next unit, before I move on the next and final unit of this, we'll think about how contemporary audiences respond to this idea of the kind of Qingming scroll culture, right. Not just this painting of Zhang, but this entire multi-century project of recreating and redesigning that imagery in different ways. In the next unit of this module, we'll look at this from a contemporary perspective.

But before we do that, there are a few more things to take care of for this unit, beginning with a somewhat more open-ended sort of brainstorming and writing prompt. So basically, focusing on the one of these three articles that we had the chance to read together in more detail, it talked a lot about this idea that an event that may have been very familiar to one generation can be forgotten by the next, and then sort of omitted from cultural memory by subsequent eras. So rather than thinking directly about the specific moment in which, of course, none of us have experienced as kind of lost to time, this reopening of the canals in the mid and early 11th, I'd like us to sort of think laterally about other versions of the same idea.

Right? Brainstorm a bit. An image that might capture some kind of event or cultural phenomenon or something that might be, let's say, instantly familiar and recognizable to someone in your parents', grandparents' generation. Whatever you can choose, but that might be something that you yourself can't really understand. Unless you have some extra information about it, right? So, an image, or a painting, or even an imagined image of something that might immediately make sense to someone from an older generation, but that you might need a little bit more help to say, well, why does this matter? Right, what is this picture representing? I need more information to make sense of it. And then I'd like us to think about maybe something from the world as we understand it today that we can't predict, but that you expect might be somewhat similar.

Right? So, later generations might not really be able to understand what this means unless we have some other kind of documentation about it. So again, this is very open-ended. It's intended to sort of spark your just to think about this kind of big distinction between experience, memory, and then the sort of later legacy and the role that images play in preserving that, but also sort of leaving some things out, right? They might sort of create some mysteries for future audiences in just the same way that Sahl argues that all of this kind of boat and grain and weather-related imagery might have made perfect sense to this 11th century audience as capturing this moment of the season, but later viewers of the painting might sort of miss out on.

those details unless someone is there to explain it. So I'd like you just to focus on the kind of creative, imaginative part of this, but the more you can connect this back to some of the points that are made in this article about how this idea sort of fades from, I think the more useful this will

be if you're thinking about other issues in this class. So, as usual, this writing assignment is very open-ended. The quiz is a bit more precise, right as we should expect quizzes to be. As with the last quiz in this module, it's five questions. You'll have 10 minutes to complete it. I will address details from all three of these scholarly perspectives. that I covered in today's lecture, but I know that you haven't had a chance to read Hansen or Yuhui's article, right?

So I'm not going to obviously go into really intense detail about individual points that are made in those two other perspectives. I do hope that you'll be familiar with the sort of general argument that these two scholars make. In the case of the article that you did read for today, though, you can expect a somewhat higher level of in the quizzes, right? One thing I'm not going to ask you to do, though, is to say, you know, which of these three perspectives is correct. I haven't really given you my opinion; I don't expect. you to be able to draw your own sort of definitive conclusion about this based on the sort of limited overview that we've provided of these three. And, as I pointed out in the conclusion, I actually think it's not really possible, right?

I think all three of these scholars make fairly persuasive arguments, leaving us in a state of kind of ambiguity or disagreement about what we actually see represented in this painting. So rather, I think what you should focus on is kind of trying to, well, what is it that each of these scholars is? And what's their rationale, right? What's the sort of shared feature of all of the evidence that they Cite that contributes to that argument. And that will help you prepare for this quiz. All right, thanks everybody. And I'll see you for the third and final lecture in the next unit of the class on the Qingming Scroll in Contemporary Popular Culture. Thanks.